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Hawai'i's Dilemma

An Overextended Archipelago in Dire Need of a Reversal

Rapa Nui, also known as Easter Island, is known for its giant anthropomorphic statues that watch the island from the coastline. These statues, called Moai, are not to be viewed lightheartedly: they symbolize a societal fall from grace caused by a heightened focus on social capital and neglect for environmental sustainability. In his book, *Collapse*, Historian and Pulitzer Prize-winning author Jared Diamond outlines the main factors that drive societies to failure. Diamond discusses the European "discovery" of the island in 1722, by explorer Jacob Rogeveen. The explorers found an island with gargantuan statues, which was perplexing because the population of natives was less than a few thousand and the land was barren with no large trees or bushes. The island had once been a complex hierarchical society with a population of up to 30,000 and the food to feed it (Diamond 90). In order to construct such marvels, the island society must have been one of surplus and wealth, with trees large enough to make rope, and ground fertile enough to feed specialized workers. In 1774,

Moai left in transport between quarry and coastline (Trustees of the British Museum)

British explorer James Cook described the natives as "small, lean, timid, and miserable" so what happened (Cook)? In short, the natives were living luxurious lives in such abundance that the manpower, supplies, and food needed to construct the Moai were hardly a factor. The population of the island began to exceed the resources that the island had to offer. Because of the island's isolation, moving or importing resources was not an option. The lifestyle of surplus on Rapa Nui quickly came to an end when the last tree was chopped and the fields didn't yield enough crops (Diamond). Rapa Nui serves as a grave example of what can happen when a society chases social, political, and economic capital without being cognizant of climate.

Understanding the reality of economic growth and the impact of different philosophies of market forces is necessary to understand how ecological destruction and climate change originate and how those problems can be addressed. To start, market growth is not infinite. The idea of infinite market growth originated late in the 19th century and became popular because of the writings of famous economists like Alfred Marshall. The British economist is considered to be one of the most influential economic thinkers in history. Marshall wrote the first textbook on economics, "Principles of Economics" where he elaborates on the idea that markets can grow indefinitely. In his book, he claims that businesses will continue to grow and capture new markets, and that competition between businesses in the market would lead to innovation and discovery. These new innovations, he claimed, would create new sources of revenue that could be capitalized on indefinitely leading to unlimited market growth (Marshall).

Economic philosophy is beginning to distance itself from the ideas popularized by Marshall and is instead developing a new mantra of ethical consumption. In 1970, a research team at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology put Marshall's philosophy under direct scrutiny and in 1972 they published *Limits to Growth*, a small paperback that flipped infinite

growth on its head. Researchers Donella Meadows, Dennis Meadows, Jorgen Randers, and William Behrens III spent two years analyzing a dynamics model called "World3" on a mainframe computer in order to better understand the implications of growth on the natural world. They came to the striking conclusion that if the human population continues to grow, spread, build, consume, and pollute the planet will reach a breaking point (Meadows). The conclusion of their study was in direct opposition to the standard western understanding of the time, but their study gained traction, especially amongst Nordic countries, selling over half a million copies in the Netherlands in a year (Ketcham). It was clear to these researchers that the time for growth was running out.

> "In any finite system there must be constraints that can act to stop exponential growth. These constraints are negative feedback loops. The negative loops become stronger and stronger as growth approaches the ultimate limit, or carrying capacity, of the system's environment. Finally the negative loops balance or dominate the positive ones, and growth comes to an end. In the world system the negative feedback loops involve such processes as pollution of the environment, depletion of nonrenewable resources, and famine."
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> **Excerpt from *The Limits to Growth* pg. 156**

Kerryn Higgs, an Australian environmental scientist, writes about this shifting paradigm in her book "Collision Course." Higgs analyzes the impacts that 20th-century capitalism had on the ordinary person: "molding [them] into a consumer with an unquenchable thirst for more" (Higgs). The transformation of the consumer, Higgs says, is a necessity of corporations in order to maintain trends of growth. Trends of continual growth rely on the use of finite resources, which are rapidly depleting, and the ultimate result is environmental destruction (Higgs).

Higgs enforces the claims made by MIT researchers and argues that policymakers, "market magic" worshippers, and corporate-funded think tanks have propagandized the evaluation of growth as a necessary central objective. Higgs and Meadows et al., effectively

establish that Marshall's infinite growth theory is not possible in a finite world. When examining climate, especially on a small scale, it is crucial to recognize that there is a limit to the population that a finite land mass can support. While fossil fuels, cows, and deforestation all contribute to climate change and ecological destruction, the underlying cause is unfettered consumption and continual growth.

With this understanding of the effects of consumption and growth, Rapa Nui's problem is clarified. The leaders on the island were so focused on expanding their own brand, and increasing their production of rope, housing, food, and statues, that they reached the tipping point and found themselves in the crosshairs of resource shortage. These earlier lessons of Rapa Nui are paralleled by another island nation, Hawai'i. Hawai'i is a crucial case study in the understanding of global trends of population growth, consumption, and resource scarcity. Hawai'i is in a vulnerable position, just like Rapa Nui, because there is an exacerbated sense of confinement and scarcity in the middle of the ocean. Hawai'i is a traveler's paradise, visiting makes people feel truly alive. The problem is that this desirability is killing the island itself. This traveler's paradox is a taxing cognitive exercise in ethical consumption.

> "[Hawai'i's] unique environments are already changing under the influence of rising ocean levels, coastal erosion, invasive species, land-use and development changes, pollution, increasing population, and natural resources demands. Global climate change is adding further stress to Hawai'i's ecosystems and resources" (Eversole).

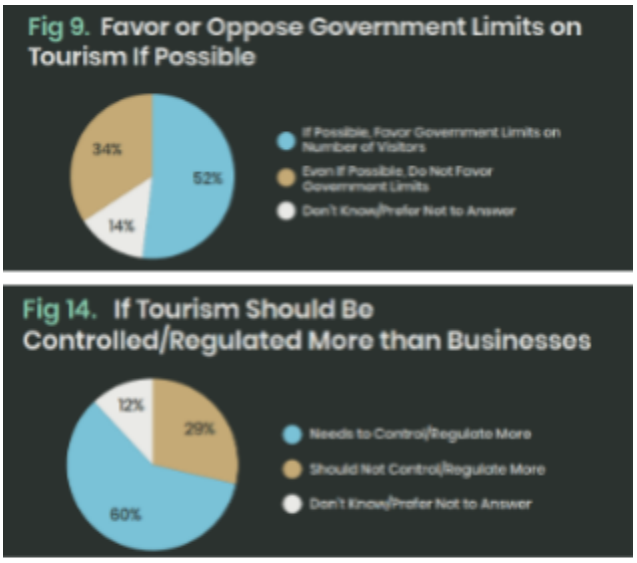
There is a long and troubled history that Hawai'i carries that explains how this situation came to be. First, James Cook's "discovery" of the island archipelago led to the creation of sugar plantations and the influx of immigration from Asia. Then, Hawai'i was annexed because of its

important position for US national interests. Now, Hawai'i is seen as the ideal vacation location for people around the world. These three major events were driven by a desire for capital: economic capital, political capital, and social capital. Although all three events have contributed to a massive influx in population and in turn resources, the focus of this paper will be the economics of the current trends of tourism and growth in Hawai'i. This growing demand for land, resources, and consumers has strained the natural habitat and led to extreme ecological duress.

Since the 1970s, Hawai'i has sustained impressive rates of growth in the tourism industry, but, it was way earlier that these trends began. In his paper, *Creating "Paradise of the Pacific": How Tourism Began in Hawaii*, James Mak, professor of economics and fellow at the University of Hawai'i Economic Research Organization, writes about the early history of Hawai'ian tourism. He describes the advent of island tourism due to "government mail subsidies to steamship companies, local funding for tourism promotion, and America's protective legislation on domestic shipping" and elaborates on the results of this government involvement (Mak). Now, over 10 million tourists visit the Hawai'ian Islands every year and tourism has created thousands of jobs and injected billions of dollars into the Hawai'ian economy totaling one-fourth of the state's employment and gross domestic product (Mak). The growth of the industry makes sense, Hawai'i does not have the capacity for factory work so outside of plantations and the military base, there are few other places to work. Like many small towns in the Midwest, Hawai'i needed to draw people in to prop up its economy. Mak's research credited tourism for being one of the few industries to provide high-paying jobs to Hawai'i's growing population. However, the economic impact of tourism is a double-edged sword, resulting in ecological damage and cultural effacing (Mak).

The government played an integral role in the development of Hawai'in tourism, and now due to how widespread and intertwined it is with the island's economic prosperity government involvement is necessary. Letting Hawai'i continue to seek infinite growth will spell disaster for the quite obviously finite ecosystem.

Government regulation and reconciliation are the only way to peacefully resolve and reverse this crisis. For one, the Hawai'ian government should increase regulations on tourism.



Public opinion polls on tourism (Knox)

The Hawai'ian Tourism Agency is a government entity that is already responsible for managing tourism in the state, but it has historically filled the role of increasing the number of tourists to the island to prop up the economy. Since the growth must end, transforming the agency to one of regulation and moderation could yield many benefits. Moreover, many residents already approve of government limits on tourism, and the idea of government limits on travelers is not novel.

Many states already have protected areas that are only accessible by a lucky few through a lottery system in order to maintain the fragile ecological conditions - for example, the Enchantment's permit raffle in Washington state. These types of regulations ensure low numbers of travelers over fragile ecosystems and lands and also reinforce good behavior from tourists. Because there is an element of scarcity, people who visit are more cognizant of the space they occupy and what they leave behind. As it stands, tourism and tourists do not pay enough

attention to the impact they have on Hawi'i's fragile ecosystem. In their report, *Coral Reefs: Tourism, Conservation and Management*, B. Prideaux and Anja Pabel analyze the effects of tourism on coral reefs around the globe. They found that on Maui, Hawai'i, boat-guided snorkel tours resulted in "damage to reefs" and "fauna destruction" (Prideaux). With the scale of tourist operations like these, regulation is an easy way to combat the damage to the natural ecology. Past government regulations like the Covid-19 travel bans where travel to the islands were extremely limited resulted in the protection of the health and well-being of Hawai'ian citizens. Surely there could be an effort to protect the health and well-being of the ecology and culture of the islands.

In addition to a resource crisis, Hawai'i is also facing a space crisis. Hawai'i has the 3rd highest rate of homelessness behind DC and NY (Homeless). The growing cost of living which has been driven by an influx of transplants has resulted in many who have lived in Hawai'i for generations no longer being able to afford a home. Native Hawai'ians are disproportionately affected too, they comprise 10% of the state's population but one-third of the homeless population (Stinton). The prices of housing and goods markets indicate growth and increasing value in the state of Hawai'i, as they are constantly increasing. When there is a finite amount of space and building materials, housing prices skyrocket. Hawai'i is now at the nexus point between growth and destruction, and the housing crisis is an example of a negative feedback loop that the World3 model predicted (Meadows). Government regulation is needed to end this growth and surplus mentality and reverse the effects on the climate.

There are two solutions to the problem of housing: fight the inevitable and build more houses or alleviate population pressures. Clearing land in Hawai'i and expanding housing will only exacerbate the ecological crisis the island is facing. So, the government must find an avenue to reduce the island's population. Just like how at its dawn the Hawai'ian government

campaigned for people to move to the island, the state should now focus on public campaigns to encourage mainland migration and discourage new transplants. There are a couple of necessary caveats to this claim. First, the government must focus on convincing recent transplants off the island and avoid any sentiment toward native populations moving. Second, the government should attempt to avoid pushing lower-class residents off the island. A possible avenue that would address both issues would be tax reform. Implementing an extremely progressive tax policy, large taxes on building expensive housing, and heavy taxes on big purchases would discourage the wealthy from moving to Hawai'i and encourage those currently there to move away. While it seems targeted, the wealthy population is ultimately responsible for the many ecological problems on the islands. In her article on the wealth divide in Hawai'i, Tariro Mzezewa, a travel reporter for the New York Times, writes about the struggle of local Hawai'ians due to the wealthy population. Mzezewa writes that many wealthy people move to the islands because they imagine them as a "playland," but to locals, Hawai'i has become a place of financial struggle and cultural dismissal with rising costs and gentrification (Mezezewa).

The government still continues to play a large role in damage to Hawai'ian ecology and culture. Mauna Kea, the largest mountain from base to peak in the world, is a sacred place to the people of Hawai'i. Despite its sacredness, beauty, and prominence as a natural wonder, the government is adamant about building a telescope at its peak (Jones). Government action like this is directly contrary to any claims of preservation and conservation of natural lands. The government should not only erase its expansionist and growth mindset but should also raise and delegate funds to the restoration of Hawai'i's natural lands. Either by delegating part of the state budget or by selling government bonds like in New York in 2022, the government of Hawai'i

needs to fund restoration projects for the beaches, forests, mountains, and coastlines that are eroding, filled with trash, and dying (New York).

Hawai'i's growth has been caused by a constant pursuit of economic growth without consideration for the beautiful natural ecology that the island possesses. Being a small island nation, the ecosystem of Hawai'i is extremely delicate, and the growing industry and population has given it immense strain. Overpopulation in Hawai'i has had an immense impact on the ecology and climate, but there is still time to reverse the trend before Hawai'i's resources are totally exhausted. But like Rapa Nui, Hawai'i will fall from grace if it keeps cutting down trees and quarrying rocks in the venture for capital accumulation. Although the state has taken some measures to address the issue, such as establishing protected areas and encouraging sustainable development, more needs to be done to combat the root of the problem: consumption. Government action in the form of regulation and monetary support is needed to slow and ultimately reverse the effects of climate change and ecological destruction that has been caused by the growing population and tourism industry on the Hawai'ian islands. Without intervention, one of the world's most beautiful locations will be destroyed by people who simply seek to experience its gracious and sublime landscape. In order to make a real difference, a comprehensive and collaborative effort from all stakeholders is essential.

Word Count: 2,652

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